

HYPOTHETICAL INCIDENT · PUBLIC FACTS ONLY

When the platform breaks

An FDE's **playbook** · *Cyber Monday at Nespresso* · Dec 1, 2025

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I The scenario · Cyber Monday at Nespresso ANZ

DEC 1, 2025 · 9:00 AM AEDT · BIGGEST GIFTING DAY OF THE YEAR

SYMPTOMS · WHAT'S BREAKING

- Site search **p95 latency: 200ms → 4-8s**
- **~8%** of queries returning errors or 0 results
- Personalized recs regressing to generic for **~75%** of logged-in traffic

BUSINESS IMPACT · WHAT'S AT STAKE

- Search conversion lift **3:1 → 0.5:1** (worse than browse)
- **~\$4-6M AUD** at risk over 4-hour peak window
industry benchmark · New Relic 2024 · \$1M USD/hr median
- YC Eu (Head of E-Business, Nespresso Oceania) DMs me at **07:47 AEDT**

FIRST-HOUR TIMELINE · THE FDE PERSPECTIVE

07:15 Nespresso Datadog SLO burn-rate alert · search-API p95
07:30 Nespresso's zero-result monitor (custom dashboard on Coveo Analytics) breaches → FDE paged
07:47 YC Eu DMs (informed by her ops team) – third signal, not first
09:00 **PEAK HOUR · first hypothesis verified**
11:00 Stabilized

I My first hour · the RCA playbook

Four checks · ~25 minutes · each rules in or out a category of cause

#	RULES IN / OUT	CHECK (NESPRESSO-SPECIFIC)	WHERE	TIME
1	Coveo-side recent changes	Activity Browser audit (last 7d) + Coveo Status Page · Friday Cyber Monday rule + Sunday ML retrain(s) visible w/ model name + timestamp + author	Coveo Admin Console	~5 min
2	Coveo vs Nespresso stack + rate-limit	search-API p95 vs Sunday baseline · errors clustered by query type · HTTP status-code breakdown (429s = rate-limit smoking gun) · spike at 07:15 (32min before exec DM)	Shared Datadog · weekly sprint dashboard	~5 min
3	Single query path + ML serving capacity	Relevance Inspector (paste searchUid) · &debug=true execution report · Inspect ML Models — iterate every model deployed on Nespresso's pipeline for live behavior + per-model concurrency + serving latency	Coveo Admin Console	~7 min
4	Source push + data integrity	Push/Stream API queue depth · Data Health Overview + Event Browser · Log Browser w/ LogResponseBodyWhenUnsuccessful	Sources + Data Health + Log Browser	~7 min

FDE'S COMPLETE COVEO DIAGNOSTIC TOOLKIT

Platform health Watchtower + Status page · **Resource audit** Activity Browser · **Per-query forensics** Relevance Inspector + **&debug=true** · **ML behavior** Inspect ML Models + Review Model Info · **Source-side** Log Browser + **LogResponseBodyWhenUnsuccessful** · **Data integrity** Data Health (Overview + Event Browser) · **Programmatic ops** Coveo CLI · **Safe test** sandbox organization

I Hypothesis ranking · cheap-to-verify first

Six competing root causes · two starred · all parallelizable

LOW VERIFICATION COST

HIGH VERIFICATION COST

HIGH LIKELIHOOD

★ Query Pipeline rule misfire

Friday's Cyber Monday rule · most recent change · #1 Coveo failure mode
→ `rollback ~30 sec via Activity Browser`

Cache TTL alignment under spike

cache keys expire together at TTL boundary · thundering herd → origin overload · industry-known peak-event pattern
→ `requires cache flush to verify · risky during peak`

★ Per-org QPS rate-limit ceiling

5-7× traffic exceeds Coveo Care plan's negotiated QPS allocation · token-bucket overflow → 8% intermittent HTTP 429 (matches symptom pattern exactly)
→ `check HTTP 429 share in Activity Browser + Datadog · CSM lifts quota in ~15 min`

ML behavior anomaly · deployed models

First inventory Nespresso's deployed models via `Inspect ML Models` (commerce stack typically: ART · SE · Recs · QS · RGA · PR). Two sub-causes share same surface: (a) Sunday retrain regression — ART is top suspect (retrains on per-customer UA) · (b) ML serving saturated under 5-7× concurrency
→ `dissociate the affected model ~2 min · if serving-saturated, Coveo scales ML pool`

LOW LIKELIHOOD

DNS · TLS · endpoint reachability

Coveo org-subdomain TLS · ANZ → Coveo DNS resolution · CDN ↔ Coveo handshake · 8% intermittent argues against (DNS usually 100% failure) — but always verify it's not DNS
→ `curl -v + dig from ANZ region · ~60 sec total`

Coveo platform sub-region issue

Status page says OK · but status pages lag actual incidents by 5-30 min · last resort only
→ `page Coveo Platform Eng on-call · internal #platform-eng Slack · keep Support Manager looped in`

Immediate stabilization · parallel tracks

Top hypotheses mitigated in parallel · per-track analysis automated by spawning Claude subagents · all reversible · tracked as Jira + GitHub PR

T+0MIN

T+15MIN

T+30MIN

TRACK A · Query Pipeline rule rollback ★

JIRA CVO-SUP-NES-CM01-A · git revert PR linked · Coveo FDE owner

Revert Friday's Cyber Monday rule via [Activity Browser](#) → verify in Activity Browser → measure zero-result rate. **Fastest reversible action** · ~5 min end-to-end.

TRACK B · CSM lifts per-org QPS quota ★

JIRA CVO-SUP-NES-CM01-B · Coveo CSM owner · Coveo FDE escalates

Page Coveo CSM + Account Manager → temporarily raise Nespresso's QPS ceiling for the peak window. **~15 min end-to-end** · Coveo platform supports this as a documented operational lever for peak events.

TRACK C · Troubleshoot deployed ML models

JIRA CVO-SUP-NES-CM01-C · Coveo FDE + Coveo Eng owner

Iterate [Inspect ML Models](#) across Nespresso's deployed models (ART · SE · Recs · QS · RGA · PR) · check serving latency · per-model concurrency · retrain quality. **Branch fix** based on finding: **output regression** → dissociate offending model ~2 min (falls back to baseline) · **serving saturation** → Coveo scales ML pool.

TRACK D · Edge throttling at Nespresso CDN

JIRA NES-INC-2025-CM01-D · Nespresso eng owner · their PR · **defense-in-depth**

Rate-limit search-API at CDN edge · protect upstream · buys 15 min to verify A, B, C. Doesn't fix root cause — prevents cascade.

Mitigation BEFORE RCA (Google SRE) · *"Customers don't care whether or not you fully understand the cause; they want to stop receiving errors."*

I Verification & handback · don't walk away too soon

Stabilization has three phases · the FDE doesn't release until the customer's team is verbally confident

STEP 1

Fix is holding

T+30 to T+60

- ☐ Zero-result rate < 2% baseline
- ☐ Search-API p95 < 500ms
- ☐ Conversion lift restored (search vs browse)
- ☐ Personalization rendering for logged-in users

STEP 2

Hold through peak

T+60 to T+4hr

- ☐ No degradation as traffic ramps to peak
- ☐ Joint Coveo + Nespresso eng in shared Slack Connect
- ☐ Cache hit rate trending healthy
- ☐ Watch for relapse · most failures happen here

STEP 3

Handback to normal ops

T+4hr

- ☐ Step 1 metrics held 3+ hrs through peak
- ☐ YC Eu's team verbally confident
- ☐ Post-incident review scheduled (T+24hr)
- ☐ War room channel transitioned to read-only

The 16-hour timezone problem · Nespresso ANZ is UTC+11 · Coveo Montréal is UTC-5. If the incident persists past Nespresso's end-of-day, the IC role must hand off — structured pinned summary · verbal transfer *"You're now the Incident Commander, okay?"* per Google SRE · call recording for context · pre-positioned regional FDE on-call.

Slide 10 Item 5: geographic FDE distribution · not "more Montréal FDEs."

I Communication architecture · plug into existing channels

Five audiences · five channels · five cadences · FDE in hub-and-spoke position

AUDIENCE	CHANNEL	CADENCE	WHAT GOES THERE
Coveo war room (internal)	#inc-nespresso-cm2025-search Slack	Real-time	Diagnosis · technical detail · decisions
Nespresso tech team	Shared Slack Connect (from weekly sprint cadence) + phone bridge	Real-time	Tactical updates · joint action · paste logs
YC Eu + her execs	Email + Slack Connect	Every 30 min hot · hourly stabilizing	Calibrated status · always names next update time
Coveo internal leadership	#incident-updates broadcast	Per milestone	Visibility for Technical Success Director · SVP Customer & Value Engineering · Chief Customer Success Officer · doesn't interrupt war room
Nespresso wider org	Routed via YC Eu (we don't go around her)	She decides	Single point of contact discipline

ANTI-PATTERNS TO AVOID

- Silent gaps > 30 min during hot phase (silence breeds exec drive-bys)
- Fake ETAs · use "unknown" + commit to next update time
- Split-brain · Zoom war room + Slack thread with no single source of truth
- War room staying open after the incident is over

Sample exec note · T+15min · written under pressure

~140 words · scope quantified · hypothesis named · next update time committed

To: YC Eu <yc.eu@nespresso.com>
Cc: Coveo Support Manager · Coveo CSM
Subject: [INCIDENT] Search platform · T+15min · 08:02 AEDT

YC,

We're seeing intermittent search failures at Nespresso ANZ that started ~07:15 AEDT. Initial scope: ~8% of search queries are returning errors or zero results, and personalized recommendations are regressing to generic for logged-in users. Estimated impact: search conversion lift dropping from your 3:1 baseline toward 0.5:1.

Top two hypotheses right now: (1) the Friday Cyber Monday query pipeline rule misfiring, (2) we may be hitting your contracted Coveo throughput ceiling at this traffic level. Both are cheap to verify — we're rolling back the rule and engaging Coveo's CSM to temporarily raise your throughput ceiling, in parallel. Expect confirmation in the next 15 min.

Nespresso eng is in the shared Slack Connect channel with me.

Next update: 08:32 AEDT regardless of progress.

— Franck Benichou
Forward Deployed Engineer · Coveo

"~8% · ~07:15 AEDT · 3:1 → 0.5:1"

Scope quantification · specific is credible · forwardable to her CMO

"Top two hypotheses (1) + (2)"

Named hypothesis is data, not vibes · wrong is recoverable, silent isn't

"Both cheap to verify"

Signals discipline, not random fixes

"Next update: 08:32 AEDT regardless"

Commitment to a clock removes "is he ignoring us?" anxiety

No fake ETA on resolution

Trust-preserving honest uncertainty · industry standard

| Post-incident actions · within 24 hours of stabilization

Every deliverable is a Jira ticket or GitHub PR · no tribal knowledge · no ad-hoc work

Blameless post-mortem · joint Coveo + Nespresso

1

Filed as Jira ticket in both instances · facts · timeline · decisions · what we didn't know · permanent record

FDE DRAFTS · JOINT REVIEW

Runbook addition · Nespresso ANZ playbook

2

Markdown in customer-config GitHub + Coveo FDE pattern library (Confluence) · same pattern doesn't burn the same hours twice

FDE

Monitoring gap closure

3

The alert that should have fired at 07:15 is now added · Datadog SLO burn-rate + tightened zero-result alert in Nespresso's monitoring dashboard · GitHub PR

JOINT COVEO + NESPRESSO

Load test on Nespresso sandbox

4

Reproduce Cyber Monday conditions · validate fix holds · catch regressions before Boxing Day · CI-runable

COVEO ENGINEERING

Public RCA to Nespresso stakeholders

5

Executive-readable · no scapegoating · accuracy over speed · management review before publish · YC Eu shares with her CMO/COO/CEO

FDE + COVEO CSM

Internal Coveo product feedback

6

File Coveo Product Jira if incident revealed platform gap · status-page lag · pause-ML-retrain control · staging-test mode for rules

FDE

| Structural prevention · the FDE's investment proposal

Each item is a tracked ticket · owner · priority · ETA · monthly review with Nespresso + Coveo CSM

TICKET	ROOT CAUSE / ISSUE	CHANGE	OWNER	PRIORITY	ETA
CV0-FDE-NES-2025-001	<i>No quantified failure budget · no auto-freeze when burn-rate spikes</i>	Coveo SLO + error-budget · <i>99% queries <500ms · 99.5% non-zero</i> · burn-rate freezes retrains + rule changes	Coveo CSM + FDE	P1	6 wks
CV0-FDE-NES-2025-002	<i>Risky changes shipped during peak window (Friday rule + Sunday retrain landed mid-peak)</i>	Peak-window change freeze · no ML retrains · no Query Pipeline rule changes · Black Friday → Boxing Day	Joint	P1	2 wks
CV0-FDE-NES-2025-003	<i>Runbook untested between incidents · response skills decay without practice</i>	Quarterly incident-response drill · simulated incident run with Nespresso eng + FDE · stress-test the runbook · update gaps before next peak event	FDE	P2	Q1 26
CV0-FDE-NES-2025-004	<i>Nespresso eng can't self-diagnose · FDE-as-bottleneck on small issues</i>	Public-share Coveo observability dashboard · YC Eu's team self-diagnoses simple issues without paging me	FDE	P2	8 wks
CV0-FDE-NES-2025-005	<i>16h Montréal ↔ ANZ gap · midnight IC handoff with no coverage</i>	24/7 regional FDE rotation · APAC + EMEA + Americas coverage · removes the 16h timezone single-point-of-failure	Coveo (org-level)	P1	Q3 26
CV0-FDE-NES-2025-006	<i>Sandbox drift from prod · changes deploy without safe-test gate</i>	Sandbox synchronization discipline · daily <code>coveo org:resources:pull</code> from prod → sandbox · safe-test-before-deploy	FDE + Nespresso	P1	4 wks
CV0-FDE-NES-2025-007	<i>Console clicks · no PR review · no audit trail · no rollback path</i>	Coveo CLI + git-based deployment · every rule, ML config, IPE Python ships through PR · CLI push from CI/CD	FDE	P1	6 wks
CV0-FDE-NES-2025-008	<i>Peak QPS exceeded contracted ceiling · mid-incident scramble for CSM</i>	Pre-negotiated peak-window QPS ceiling lifts · CSM + FDE forecast peak QPS for each known event (Cyber Monday · Black Friday · Boxing Day · Valentine's) · contracted ceiling raises arranged in advance	Coveo CSM + FDE	P1	4 wks

Items 6 + 7 = direct bridge to Topic 1 · the same Coveo CLI + sandbox + version-controlled config pattern I shipped for the Pokémon Challenge ([config/](#) , [scripts/](#) , [bootstrap.sh](#)). **Coveo's platform supports this discipline natively at enterprise scale — it just needs to be activated at the customer.**

Speed of communication · Quality of diagnosis · Discipline of prevention

Cyber Monday at Nespresso · an FDE's playbook

QUESTIONS?

I Appendix · sources (1 of 2)

Coveo platform tooling · escalation process · operational discipline

COVEO ESCALATION + CASE MANAGEMENT

- Case management process · docs.coveo.com/en/1489
- Coveo Care · Customer Support & Success Guide
- Coveo Care Plans · Pro vs Enterprise
- Coveo FDE public job description · fwddeploy.com
- Coveo x SupportLogic · -53% MTTR

COVEO DIAGNOSTIC TOOLKIT

- Relevance Inspector
- Debug query info · `&debug=true` execution report
- Inspect ML Models
- Review Model Information
- Data Health Monitoring + Event Browser
- Log Browser · `LogResponseBodyWhenUnsuccessful`
- Manage Query Pipelines · Activity log

CODE-AS-SOURCE-OF-TRUTH (TOPIC 1 BRIDGE)

- Coveo CLI · main page
- CLI · Manage organization snapshots
- CLI · CI/CD pipeline pattern
- Sandbox organizations
- Critical Updates mechanism
- Manage ML model associations · dissociate, A/B

INDEXING PIPELINE + CONTENT

- Coveo Indexing Pipeline
- Catalog object types · Product · Variant · Availability
- Coveo for Adobe (AEM, not Commerce)
- Troubleshoot query error codes
- ML overview + retraining

I Appendix · sources (2 of 2)

Industry SRE patterns · Nespresso scenario anchors · IC + war-room references

INCIDENT COMMAND + WAR ROOM (INDUSTRY)

- Google SRE · Managing Incidents
- Google SRE · Shakespeare Search postmortem
- Rootly · Incident Commander Guide
- Coralogix · What is an Incident Commander
- Upstat · War Room Protocols

COMMUNICATIONS + RCA DISCIPLINE

- incident.io · Incident Communication Best Practices
- PagerDuty · Dedicated Incident Channels
- Atlassian Statuspage · Incident Comms
- Runframe · 8 Incident Communication Templates
- Cloudflare · Customer Incident Management Policy

MULTI-VENDOR + ON-CALL + ADOBE

- Adobe Commerce · Shared Responsibility
- PagerDuty · Managing Vendor Incidents
- Rootly · Distributed Global On-Call
- SRE School · Follow the Sun
- Bhagya Rana · 12 Postmortem Lessons

NESPRESSO SCENARIO · CYBER MONDAY BENCHMARKS

- Coveo case study · Nespresso
- Coveo blog · Nespresso B2C search
- ClickZ ShopTalk 2025 · YC Eu + Peter Curran
- Retail TouchPoints · Nespresso Coffee Quiz (Monetate, NOT Coveo)
- Adobe Analytics 2025 · Cyber Monday data
- New Relic · retail outage cost benchmark